January 2024 Social Security Administration (SSA) Cost of Living (COLA) Adjustment and Related Changes	Number	Page
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Effective Date:
1/1/2024

Background:
The annual Cost of Living Adjustment (COLA) occurs for Social Security (SSA) Title II payments, Supplemental Security Income (SSI)/State Supplementary Payment (SSP) payments, the In-Kind Support and Maintenance (ISM) levels for computing Pickle eligibility, 2023 Pickle Disregard computation chart, Federal Benefit Rate, Medicare Premiums, Substantial Gainful Activity (SGA), and the SSI standard and parental allocation amounts.

Purpose:
To provide guidance for processing the 2024 SSA COLA and update the Medi-Cal Assistance Standards chart with 2024 values.

Policy:
There will be a 3.2 percent COLA increase to SSA Title II Retirement, Survivors, and Disability Insurance payments effective January 1, 2024. This increase will not apply to Federal Poverty Level (FPL) programs (Aged and Disabled FPL, Blind FPL, and Medicare Savings Programs) until April 2024. The California Healthcare Eligibility, Enrollment, and Retention System (CalHEERS) is not running a COLA update until the FPLs are updated in April, so Modified Adjusted Gross Income (MAGI) cases will not be affected at this time. The Department of Health Care Services (DHCS) will notify affected MAGI beneficiaries when CalHEERS runs the COLA update next year. Beneficiaries may contact the county for a re-evaluation back to January 1, 2024, if they were impacted.

NOTE: Negative action must not be taken on cases that fall under the continuous coverage group (active prior to 4/1/2023) until a full unwind redetermination is completed during their annual renewal month.

The following Maintenance Need Assistance Standards charts have been updated with the 2024 values:

- SSI/SSP payment cash grant levels for determining Pickle eligibility
- ISM for determining Pickle eligibility
- Pickle disregard computation chart
- Federal Benefit Rate
- SSI standard, Community Spouse, and parental allocation amounts
- Medicare premiums
- SGA

Procedure:
Use the updated Maintenance Need Assistance Standards chart when evaluating the appropriate programs. Do not apply the COLA prematurely to FPL and MAGI based programs.

Program Impact/s:

The California Statewide Automated Welfare System (CalSAWS) applied the COLA and completed a mass update of Medi-Cal cases over the weekend of December 02, 2023. Cases that did not have the SSA income or Medicare Part B premium amount(s) updated must be reviewed and authorized. The lists will be available on SharePoint.

NOTE: Cases that are in the continuous coverage group were not authorized in the COLA run and must be reviewed during their annual renewal month.

References:
ACWDLs 23-24, 23-25, 23-26, and 23-27

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance on or by 12/31/2024.

Approval for Release:

For:

Rick Wanne, Director
Self-Sufficiency Services